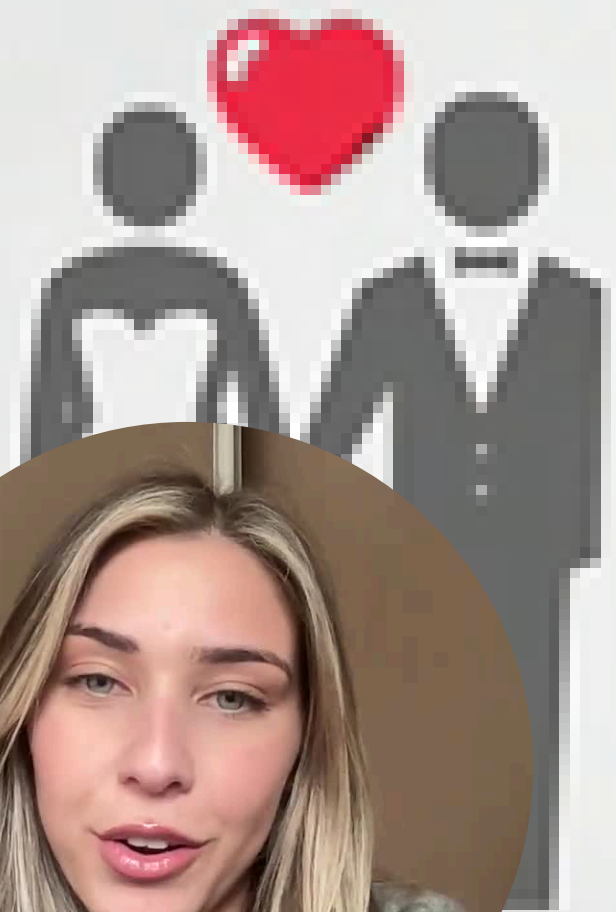
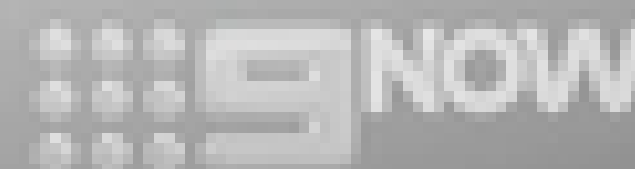




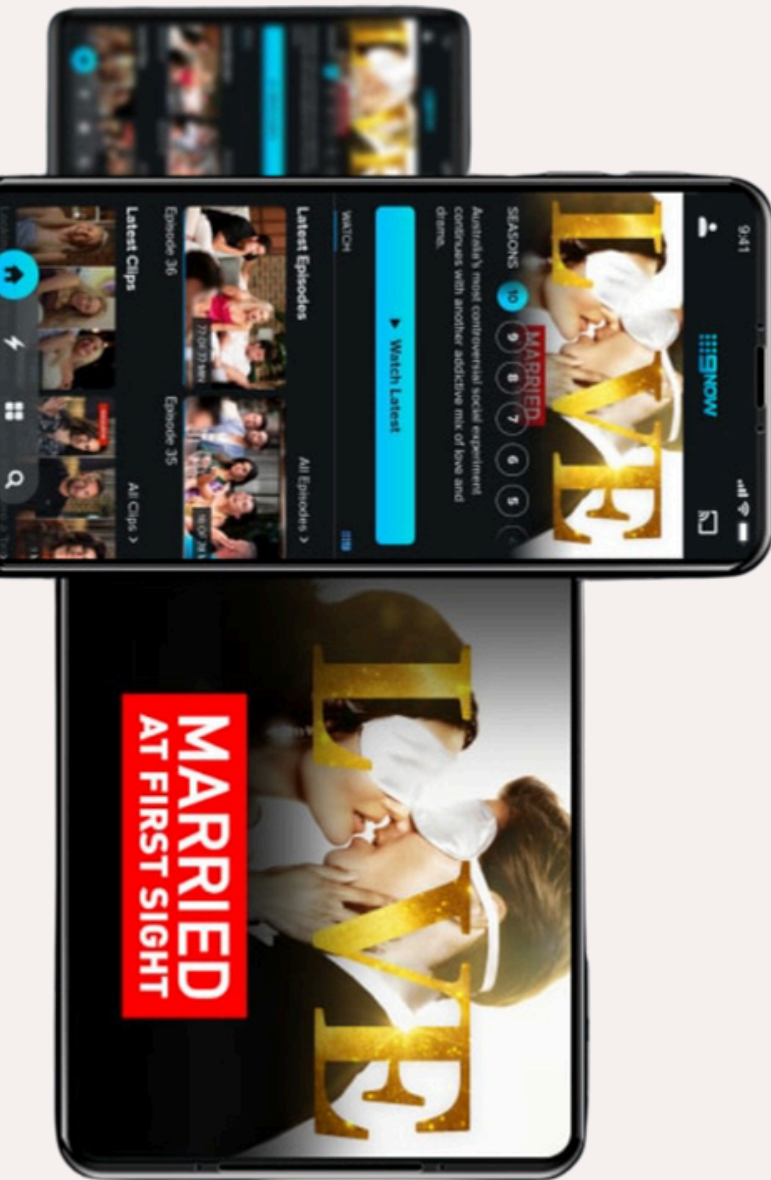
MARRIED AT FIRST SIGHT

LOVE, DRAMA, AND REALITY TV: A CRITICAL ANALYSIS OF MARRIED AT FIRST SIGHT

PRESENTED BY: NAT, NIKKI,
JACKIE, DANAE AND PHUONG
DUNG



Program Overview



2024**



No.1

- **Show:** Married at First Sight (MAFS)
- **Network:** Lifetime, 9now
- **Season/Episode:** Season 11, Episode 25 (2024)
- **Genre:** Reality TV, Social Experiment



No.2

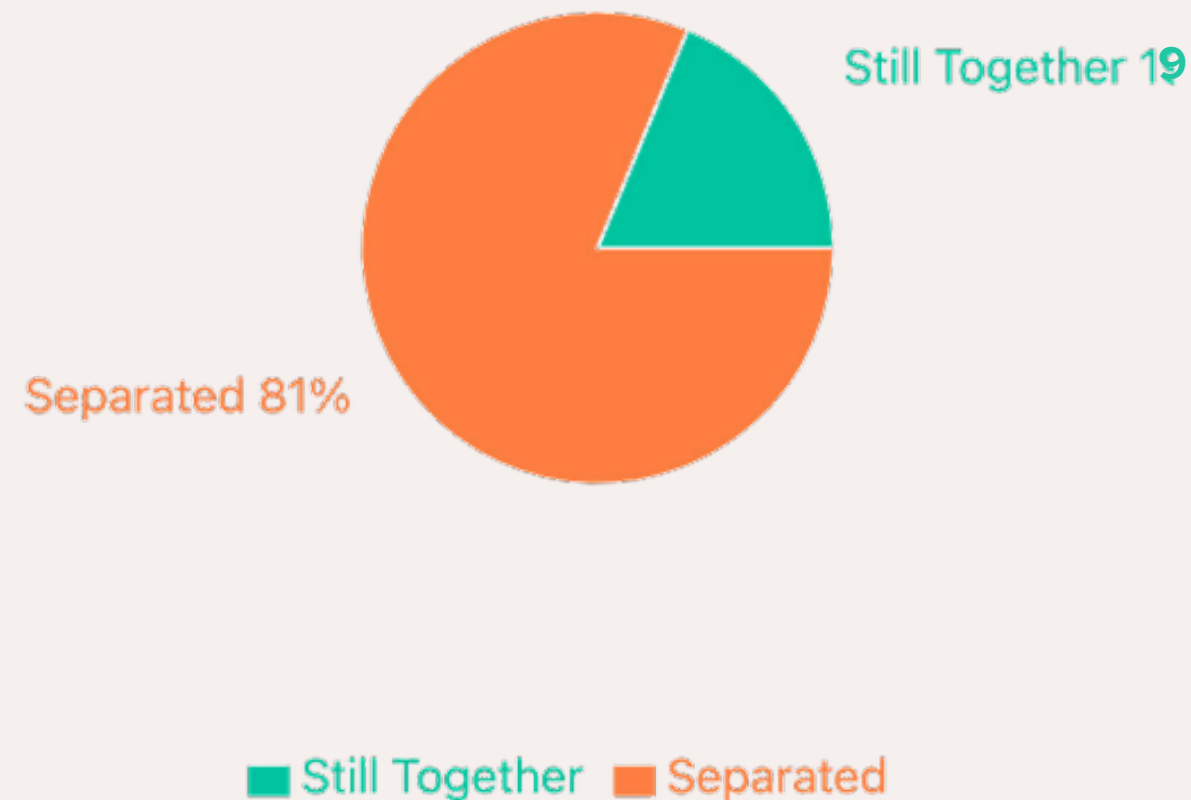
Married at First Sight (MAFS) is a reality TV show whereby strangers get paired up and married the first time they see each other. The show follows the couple's journeys, with weekly check ins to decide if they want to stay or leave their marriage. At the end of each season, couples choose whether they want to progress with the relationship in the real world, or terminate it after the experiment.



No.3

Thesis: "This episode exemplifies how reality TV shapes narratives around love, marriage, and personal growth, while raising questions about authenticity and representation."

Married at First Sight: Couple Success Rate

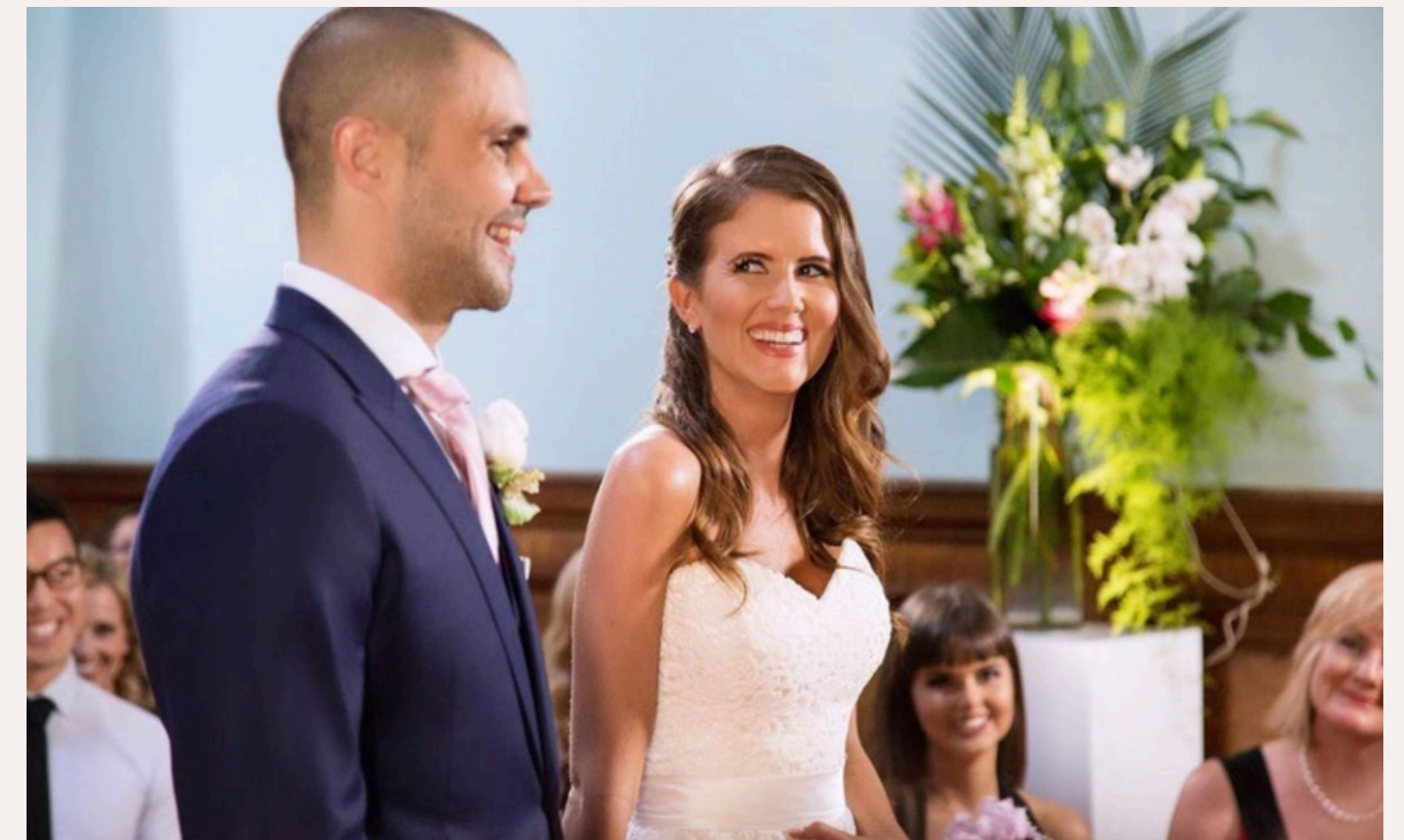


Out of 64 couples matched over 17 seasons, only 12 are still together, resulting in a success rate of 18.75%.

Serena N (2024)

Key Examples:

1. Longest-lasting couple: Erin Bateman and Bryce Mohr (Season 2, 2016)
2. Recent success story: Kerry Knight and Johnny Balbuziente (Season 8, 2021) - engaged
3. Unexpected split: Tahnee Cook and Ollie Skelton (Season 10, 2023) - fan favorites who recently separated



Couple, Erin and Bryce

Emblematic Features And Characteristics Analysis Of S11. Ep. 25



KEY EVENTS

Season 11, Episode 25 of *Married at First Sight Australia* is a pivotal point in the show, as the remaining couples face crucial moments in their relationships.

- Participants must decide whether: They want to stay together and continue their journey outside of the controlled environment of the experiment.

(Ex: Couples facing each other in a formal setting, expressing their final decisions with intense background music.)

=> This decision-making process heightens the drama and emotional intensity, as couples reflect on their time together and the challenges they've faced.

- Aftermath Discussions and Expert Analysis: Couples discuss their future plans or reflect on their experiences, while the show's experts provide insights on each couple's journey, decisions, and potential for future success.

(Ex: Close-up shots of participants expressing their doubts or hopes before the final decision then Experts discussing the couples' body language and communication patterns during their final interactions.)

Overall, Episode 25 sets the stage for dramatic final decisions, full of emotional highs and lows

Emblematic Features And Characteristics Analysis Of S11. Ep. 25

KEY THEMES IN THIS EPISODE:

- Relationship trust, personal growth, and emotional vulnerability.
- Some couples may experience breakthroughs, while others struggle with doubts about their future compatibility. The tension and anticipation are emblematic of what makes MAFS so captivating—viewers are drawn to the emotional stakes, raw authenticity, and unpredictability of whether couples will choose to stay together or part ways.



CONTRIBUTION TO POPULARITY

- These features create a emotionally charged narrative that keeps viewers invested.
- The mix of expert analysis and personal drama appeals to both viewers seeking relationship insights and those enjoying the entertainment value.
- The decision-making process creates a sense of audience participation, as viewers often form their own opinions about the couples.



Rationale for Selection



- **Social Commentary and Discussions:** MAFS often sparks social discussions about modern relationships, gender roles (Ouellette, L., & Wilson, J. 2011), and societal expectations (Skeggs, B., & Wood, H. 2012). The extreme situations on the show create a lot of debate and analysis, which fans enjoy engaging in both online and with friends (Deery, J. 2015)

- **Character Attachment:** Viewers often get attached to certain participants (Barton, K. M. 2009), rooting for their success or enjoying the “villains” who cause tension (Montemurro, B. 2008). This character-driven storytelling keeps audiences hooked season after season (Hall, A. 2009)

- **Drama and Conflict:** MAFS is known for its intense and often explosive drama, whether it’s romantic entanglements, betrayals, or confrontations. Viewers are drawn to the emotional rollercoasters that make it feel unpredictable and entertaining (Reiss, S., & Wiltz, J. 2004).



This deep emotional engagement is evidenced by the show's in high rate of viewers comparing to others shows

Show	Network	National TV Audience	Total Viewers	BVOD Audience
Married At First Sight (Season 11 Premiere)	Nine	1.25 million	2.46 million	189,000
Australian Idol	Seven	787,000	1.78 million	Not specified
Survivor	Ten	572,000	1.13 million	Not specified

Table 1: The number of viewers based on network in Australia (sevenone studios 2024)

2 minute exert of our selected episode.



Short extract analysis

SOUND

- All of this unfolds with the added effect of dramatic music. The sound builds dramatically when the group is about to reveal the cheating scandal and music gets louder in volume and higher in pitch. The sounds are also quite jarring, aligning with the taboo and uncomfortable nature of discussion at hand.

MODE OF VIEWERS ADDRESS

- The mode of viewers address for our show is very informal. Unlike a news presenter, the characters on our show are just communicating causally with one another, like they would with a normal partner, so there is no need for proper language. The experts however do engage in some psychological jargon when psycho-analysing the participants and their chemistry.

MISE EN SCENE

- The dinner parties place controversial people opposite each other, to ignite some sort of disagreement. For most drama and therefore entertainment for their viewers. Self-serve drinks table set up away from the main dinner table. This is where smaller groups or pairs tend to break-off to gossip away from the other couples

EDITING

- Dynamic editing and cuts, jumping too and from the present. Dulled colours are employed in the parts where the character is contemplating his marriage, to set a sombre tone that matches his emotions.
- Swearing is bleeped, which reflects the scheduled timeslot in which it airs on broadcast TV. Children are likely to still be awake when it is played on Tv, which is why explicit language is removed.

(Callemain, 2021)

Complex Narrative

How does a complex narrative help understand the concept of the show?

How does MAFS differ and align with a complex narrative? (industrially + culturally)

Encourages repeated + close engagement of each episode (repeated premise + structure)

Connection to BVOD – encourages binge watching + keeping up with the narrative

- flashbacks – To have understood the backstory of the cheating scandal, you would have been a regular viewer of the show. To refresh memories of regular viewers and keep others in the loop, the show utilises flashbacks to previous pivotal moments relevant to the current drama. This contextualises the drama for the audience.
- multiple couples romantic journeys together, intersect at the dinner party that is played in the extract. Viewer is brought into the entanglement of the cheating scandal. Only regular viewers would understand the dynamics between characters that were playing out in this scene.
- depth and layers to this show that continue to develop throughout the season which demands a continued and focused viewership.
- BVOD – much easier to binge watch, which people are more likely to do, as the shows often end on a cliff hanger. This rejection of plot closure after each episode is also an example of how the show demonstrates narrative complexity By having several episodes at their disposal, viewers don't have to wait to watch, and can continue the flow of the narrative.

Defining Reality TV

Consumers and commentators often use term assuming that the listener will understand what they are talking about but, there is a lot of gray area on what actually defines the genre

The most popular link for scholars to examine was the links between Reality TV and Documentary.

Reality TV was considered as “documentary lite” and as a television form that “blurs traditional distinctions between information and entertainment, documentary and drama, public and private discourses.” (Kavka M. 2012)

Following continued analysis into shows like Big Brother, Reality TV was pegged as “either a cheap form of ‘Trash TV’ aimed at entertaining the masses, **or** a postmodern ‘nightmare’ that took hybridisation and surveillance technology too far.

Even as it grew as a genre, it was labelled as “dumbed-down” television as it’s status positions it as “programming which presents nothing of social value.” (Kavka M. 2012)



“One attraction of reality tv is that it muddies and plays with the distinction between event and program, between real life and representation” (Deery J. 2015)

At times Reality TV itself is arguing with It's audience about their own notions of reality and “caters to the savvy awareness that reality is largely contrived and mediated”

“Viewers are attracted to people being real, to raw emotions and surprising outcomes” (Deery J. 2015)

**REALITY
REALITY
REALITY**

♥♥♥ Ideology- Relationships and Infidelity

The commercial theme of this commitment ceremony is the conflict between spouses Sara and Tim, as they argue about Sara seeing her ex boyfriend during the experiment, while she was married to Tim, and the ethics of the issue.

Ethical issues

- Is it allowable to see an ex-partner without your current partner knowing?
- Is infidelity confined to sexual affairs?
- Is a marriage created for reality entertainment deserving of the respect and commitment one may find in a 'real' marriage?
- How does the gender of the 'cheater' change our perception of the issue?



Tim Caldwell and Sara Mesa



The Gender of Infidelity

Traditionally, when it comes to cheating, the male in the relationship is the assumed adulterer, playing the active role in the act, while the female in the relationship holds the more passive, oblivious role. Particularly seen in Film, Television, and Pop Culture, the male adulterer is a far wider used character trope compared to the female.

While this may appear as though women are being portrayed as innocent, it is argued that this additionally suggests that women are more submissive, weaker, and easier to manipulate, casting them as ‘the victim of infidelity.’

From a feminist perspective, the ethics of infidelity is sidelined as it’s dependent on the individual, and instead the treatment of both parties is focused upon. While no two humans and their emotions are the same, it becomes vital that any gender treated similarly for the same act. The act itself however, and the ‘empowerment of choice’ (Rosewarne, L. (2009)) can be viewed as a rebellion against traditionalism when removed of context, commitment, and ethics.

There is no masculine version of the word *slut*.

There is no masculine version of the word *mistress*.

In this episode of MAFS, Tim is seen taking a more submissive role in the relationship, as we see him waiting for Sara to call and apologise, while Sara appears more dominant, as she yells at the other participants and defends her actions.

Channel Nine Broadcasting

MAFS debuted on Channel Nine in 2015, with a new season being aired annually since. Season 11 premiered on the 29th of January earlier this year, and the finale was aired on the 8th of April with a total of 38 episodes.

The episodes were originally aired on Sundays at 7pm, and Monday, Tuesday, and Wednesday at 7:30pm, however as the season progressed, the episodes became more scarce, airing only on Sundays and Mondays.

The 7/7:30 starting time allows for MAFS to air during prime viewing time on these nights, due to the fact that during it's air time this season, it was consistently ranked number 1 each night it aired, with one outlier. Season 11 episode 25 earned 1,714,000 total viewers from it's primary airing.



After the launch of NineNow, channel nine's BVOD service, all episodes were available on demand.



Binge watching culture in relation to MAFS

Binge-Watching Transforms MAFS Viewing Experience

- Evolution from niche to mainstream viewing habit (Wayne, 2015)
- MAFS adapts narrative structure for binge-watching (Jenner, M. 2017)
- "Immersive potential" of reality TV formats (Deller, 2019)

For instance, MAFS has shown significant growth in digital viewership, with Nine reporting that the show 'has delivered an average of 538,000 viewers per episode on 9Now, up 11% on last year' (Nine for Brands, 2023)

Binge-Watching: Reshaping Viewer Engagement

- "Shows designed to be addictive" - Dr. Zoe Strapp (ABC News, 2024)
- Dopamine release keeps viewers coming back (ABC News, 2024)

=> This neurological response underscores the high level of engagement and emotional investment that viewers develop with the show's participants and outcomes.

Conclusion

Married at First Sight (MAFS) challenges traditional television portrayals of relationships and infidelity by reversing gender roles and utilizing complex narrative structures. The show's success in binge-watching landscapes as a reality show highlights the need for content creators and broadcasters to adapt to changing viewer preferences. MAFS balances traditional episodic structures with binge-friendly narrative arcs, maintaining audience engagement in a competitive streaming environment.

Thank you for listening!

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Team Charter of Responsibilities

Nat	Nikki	Danae	Jackie	Phuong Dung (Olivia)
○ Ideation ○ Editing of presentation slides ○ Initiate group discussion and keep group members on schedule	● Ideation ● Relating theory to core concepts ● Examining the key themes from the episode to investigate and discuss. Side note: Nikki will be away for the final presentation due to family commitments overseas. TBC.	● Supporting other member ● Exploration of ideologies such as gender, sexuality, and infidelity ● Channel 9 broadcasting details	● Ideation ● Researching both academic sources and information about the series ● Relating data to key concepts ● Proofreading ● Supporting other members	● Ideation ● Presentation slides editing ● Researching both academic sources and information about the series ● Examining emblematic features and characteristics analysis of S11. Ep. 25 and relevant course concepts, themes, ideas and/or issues to our discussion and analysis.
This is our team charter that outlines the responsibilities of each group member.				

Timeline	Next Steps
1. Week 8: Research and ideation phase, Content creation and analysis 2. Week 9: Compilation and slide preparation 3. Week 10: Finalize presentation and practice	1. Schedule initial group meeting led by Nat 2. Begin research phase, with Phuong Dung focusing on academic sources 3. Nikki to start examining key themes from the episode 4. Set up shared document for collaborative work 5. Phuong Dung will start drafting presentation slides 6. Plan for redistribution of Nikki's presentation role 7. Regular check-ins to ensure all members are supported and on track 8. Practice presentation, focusing on timing and transitions